

HADITH SCHOLARSHIP AS AN INSTITUTION OF TRADITION: EPISTEMIC, TEXTOLOGICAL, AND INSTITUTIONAL CRITIQUE

Monograph

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Author: Ryszhanov Serik

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ABSTRACT

This monograph presents a systemic analysis of hadith scholarship not as a body of religious texts but as a coherent institution — a stable system of practices, roles, legitimation mechanisms, and reproduction — whose function is the production, transmission, stabilization, and normative authorization of traditions. The work is conducted within a strictly non-confessional framework; its purpose is to establish what exactly the system of hadith scholarship is capable of proving by universal epistemic criteria, and where the limit of its evidential force lies.

The monograph builds its argument on four independent analytical levels, each self-sufficient and together forming a mutually reinforcing structure.

The first level is epistemic: analysis of the isnād as a testimony chain, ‘ilm al-rijāl as a speaker reliability assessment system, the mutawātir category as an argument from multiplicity, and the isnād-cum-matn analysis method from the standpoint of the philosophy of testimony (Coady, Lackey) and the logic of proof. It is shown that the structural properties of the system — self-referentiality, retrospectivity, correlation instead of independence of testimonies, and unverifiability of early links — render strict proof of authentic transmission structurally unattainable.

The second level is institutional: investigation of the mechanisms of authority formation, canonization of the corpus, reputational filtering, and normative stabilization. It is shown that hadith scholarship is oriented toward transmission, not toward historical reconstruction.

The third level is manuscript-based: analysis of chronological gaps between presumed authors and the earliest surviving manuscripts (from ~21 years for Muwaṭṭa’ fragments to 445 years for al-Bukhārī’s standard recension by al-Yūnīnī), the absence of autographs for all six canonical collections, the lacuna of radiocarbon dating, and the dispersal of the corpus without a unified catalogue.

The fourth level is textological: documentation of the absence of critical editions for all six collections, discrepancies between 'standard' editions not only in isnāds but in matn

formulations, the chaos of numbering systems, and the systemic gap vis-à-vis the infrastructure of biblical studies and classical philology.

Central conclusion: Hadith scholarship functions as an institution of canonization and attribution of traditions, but not as a system of strict historical proof. It can certify a report's belonging to the tradition and its degree of recognition within it, but cannot prove the authentic delivery of information from the primary source. This limit is conditioned not by particular defects but by the structural properties of the institution, which converge independently on the same conclusion across all four levels.

KEYWORDS

Hadith scholarship; institution of tradition; isnād; ‘ilm al-rijāl; jarḥ wa-ta‘dīl; philosophy of testimony; testimony epistemology; self-referentiality; logic of proof; historical authenticity; manuscript tradition; critical edition; radiocarbon dating; stemmatology; collation; canonization; mutawātir; isnād-cum-matn analysis; common link; attribution of tradition.

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PREFACE

This study proceeds from one fundamental observation: hadith scholarship — one of the most elaborate and methodologically developed disciplines of the Islamic scholarly tradition — has not been subjected to comprehensive institutional analysis from an external position. Apologetic literature analyses the system from within its own criteria; critical literature frequently attacks individual hadiths or biographical data about transmitters without posing the question of the institution as a whole. This monograph occupies a different position: its object is not the content of hadiths or the biography of a specific transmitter, but the architecture of proof — how the system is structured, what it produces, and what its evidential force in principle extends to.

Such a formulation of the question is not polemical. The conclusion that hadith scholarship functions as an institution of transmission and canonization, rather than as a system of strict historical verification, does not devalue either hadiths as a cultural-normative phenomenon or hadith scholarship as an intellectual tradition. It merely registers methodological boundaries — what the system actually proves, and what lies beyond the limits of its evidential capacity. This distinction is necessary for any scholar working with hadiths as source material.

The criteria applied in this work — independence of sources, external verifiability, absence of logical circularity, and principled openness to verification — are universal for historical source studies and the legal theory of evidence. They are applicable not only to the Islamic tradition: a parallel analysis would reveal analogous limitations in the oral Homeric tradition, rabbinic chains of transmission, or late biographies of early Christian authors. The universality of these criteria is not a defect but the foundation for their application.

The monograph is written for specialists in Islamic studies, historical epistemology, source studies, and the methodology of the humanities. Necessary terms of Arabic terminology are introduced in the text at first use. The analysis is limited to the Sunni canon (al-Kutub al-Sitta). Shia hadith scholarship, with its different principles of selection and different canonical collections (above all al-Kāfi by al-Kulaynī), lies outside the scope of this study and constitutes a separate topic. The monograph's conclusions do not claim universality within other traditions without additional analysis.

INTRODUCTION

Hadith scholarship is the ensemble of disciplines developed by the Islamic scholarly tradition for the transmission, evaluation, and classification of traditions (hadiths) attributed to the Messenger Muḥammad, his Companions (ṣaḥāba), and their successors (tābi‘ūn). The core of these disciplines consists of: ‘ilm al-isnād — the science of transmission chains; ‘ilm al-rijāl — the biographical science of transmitters; al-jarḥ wa-l-ta’dīl — normative criticism and certification of transmitters; ‘ilm al-matn — content criticism. In Sunni Islam, hadiths constitute the second normative source after the Quran and serve as the basis for doctrinal, legal, and ritual positions.

The system of hadith scholarship was created with the goal of certifying that a given report genuinely traces back to its claimed primary source. It is this claim that constitutes the object of the present analysis. It is not equivalent to a claim about the value or normative status of hadiths — the latter may retain normative force without strict historical proof. But it is the foundation on which the authority of the system as such is traditionally constructed.

The central question of the monograph: what exactly is the system of hadith scholarship capable of proving? Specifically: is it capable, when applying universal epistemic criteria, of proving the authentic delivery of information from a historical primary source? This question cannot be posed from within the tradition — it requires an external analytical position.

The monograph builds its argument in layers, so that each level reinforces the previous without depending on it. Part I establishes the theoretical framework. Part II analyses the institutional architecture. Part III examines structural vulnerabilities. Part IV documents the state of the manuscript base. Part V analyses the textological infrastructure. Part VI formulates the positive conclusion. The Conclusion synthesises all four levels. The structure is designed so that refutation of any one level does not collapse the argument as a whole: each level is self-sufficient.

PART I. THEORETICAL FOUNDATIONS

Chapter 1. Criteria of Strict Proof

1.1. Proof and Testimony: Basic Concepts

The concept of 'proof' in the epistemic sense denotes a procedure that allows the truth of a claim to be established on the basis of data independent of the acceptance of that claim within any particular tradition or system of authority. This concept does not coincide with 'proof' in mathematics or formal logic, but shares with them the key feature: the justification must work independently of whoever evaluates it — provided the same criteria are applied.

Four conditions that strict proof must satisfy with respect to a historical event or act of information transmission: (1) independence of grounds — the data used for justification must not be obtained from a single source or from mutually dependent sources; (2) principled verifiability — the grounds must be open to examination through sources external to the system under analysis; (3) absence of logical circularity — the proof cannot rely on elements whose reliability is itself derived from the proposition being verified; (4) stability under change of observer position — the conclusions hold under changes in the research context.

Historical source studies has developed operational criteria corresponding to these conditions: independence of sources (*Unabhängigkeit der Quellen*), external corroboration, principled falsifiability of interpretation, completeness of accounting for counter-evidence. These criteria are applied equally to Greek and Roman historiography, to Near Eastern narrative sources, and to medieval chronicles. There is no principled basis for excluding hadith material from their scope.

It must, however, be noted: the application of these criteria to hadith scholarship does not mean that they would reveal no limitations in other oral traditions — Homeric, rabbinic, or early Christian. The monograph acknowledges this. The specific character of the hadith case lies elsewhere: none of the comparable oral traditions presented itself as legally binding historical proof of the transmission of a specific statement by a specific person. The Homeric tradition made no claim that the words of Achilles were reproduced authentically; rabbinic transmission chains functioned as hermeneutic authority, not as a historically verified chain of custody. Hadith scholarship, by contrast, itself formulates the *isnād's* claim as historical: this report genuinely traces back to the Messenger — and this is a verifiable claim of fact. It is precisely this institutional claim — not an external standard — that determines the applicability of §1.1 criteria to the present subject of study.

1.2. Distinction Between Three Levels of Reliability

The monograph consistently applies a distinction between three conceptually different types of reliability, the conflation of which constitutes the source of most analytical errors in both apologetic and critical literature.

Internal-traditional reliability — recognition of a report as acceptable on the basis of procedures developed within a specific normative system. A hadith classified as ṣaḥīḥ by the criteria of ‘ilm al-rijāl and isnād is internally-traditionally reliable. This type of reliability is operational for practices within the tradition but does not provide a transition to external verification. Internal-traditional reliability is not falsehood; it is functional suitability for internal normative use.

Probabilistic reliability — assessment of the plausibility of a report in light of the totality of available data. This type of justification has epistemic meaning under two conditions: the data must be sufficiently complete, and they must be independent. When the condition of independence is violated, multiplying the number of testimonies does not reduce uncertainty about the source. The hadith system, as shown in Part III, systematically violates the condition of independence.

Historical authenticity — establishing the fact of authentic transmission of a report from the claimed historical primary source without substantial distortion. This is the most stringent level of justification. It requires the fulfilment of all four conditions of strict proof listed above. This is precisely the level that is the object of analysis in this monograph.

1.3. Philosophy of Testimony

Systematic investigation of the epistemology of testimony as a branch of analytical philosophy began with the foundational work of C.A.J. Coady, *Testimony: A Philosophical Study* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1992) (Coady 1992: 27–52). Coady first posed the question under what conditions testimonial evidence can be a source of knowledge, and showed that the reductionist position (which demands each time to reduce trust in a witness to one's own experience and induction) is untenable: a vast portion of human knowledge is in principle dependent on chains of testimonies. This does not, however, mean unconditional acceptance of any testimony — it requires theorising the conditions of reliable transmission.

Jennifer Lackey in *Learning from Words: Testimony as a Source of Knowledge* (Oxford: OUP, 2008) proposed a synthetic approach (Lackey 2008: 37–61): testimony is a source of knowledge when the conditions of the speaker's competence, sincerity, absence of grounds for distrust, and absence of a systematic cause of distortion are met. The key implication for the analysis of the hadith system: even the anti-reductionist position (which presupposes a presumption of trust in a witness) requires the absence of a systematic cause of distortion. A system in which all witnesses are formed in a unified normative environment with common incentives toward accepting certain reports creates precisely such a systematic cause.

The specific problem of chains of testimonies is their epistemic degradation: is knowledge preserved when transmitted sequentially through 5–7 links over 150–200 years before written fixation? Mathematically this depends on the probability of accurate transmission at each link: with $P < 1$ at each link, the product decreases exponentially. Critically: independent information about each link is needed to estimate P for early links — precisely the information that is structurally absent in the hadith system.

1.4. Terminological Alignment

To participate in the international academic discussion it is necessary to align the Arabic terminology of hadith scholarship with analytical concepts. This alignment is not a substantive reduction — it permits applying to hadith scholarship the criteria developed in adjacent disciplines.

Arabic Term	Analytical Equivalent	Function in the System
Isnād (isnād)	Testimony chain; chain of custody	Attribution of report to primary source through named chain
‘Ilm al-rijāl	Speaker reliability assessment	Evaluation of transmitter reliability
Jarḥ wa-ta’dīl	Normative witness evaluation	Criticism and certification of transmitters

Matn (matn)	Propositional content of testimony	Content portion of hadith
Mutawātir (mutawātir)	Mass transmission / overwhelming majority	Highest degree of transmission multiplicity
‘Adāla	Moral integrity of witness	Moral uprightness of transmitter
Ḍabt	Accuracy / retentive precision	Precision of reproduction in transmission
Samā’ (samā’)	Direct auditory transmission	Form of direct oral transmission
Ijāza (ijāza)	Authorization certificate	Permission to transmit a text
Common link	Common link (Juynboll)	Transmitter from whom several isnād branches diverge

Chapter 2. Western Scholarship on Hadith: Three Schools and Their Methodological Positions

2.1. The Sceptical School

Western academic study of hadith begins with Ignaz Goldziher. In *Muhammedanische Studien* (1889–1890) Goldziher showed that many hadiths reflect later political and theological controversies (Goldziher 1967: I, 17–85) — Umayyad-Abbasid rivalry, debates of legal schools, polemics against Qadarites and Kharijites. The conclusion: a significant portion of the hadith corpus is a product of its time rather than authentic tradition from the first generation. Goldziher's work opened the discussion but did not close it: he did not develop a systematic method of dating hadiths.

Joseph Schacht in *The Origins of Muhammadan Jurisprudence* (1950) proposed an operational argument (Schacht 1950: 4–20). Introducing the concept of 'common link' (the node in the isnād network from which several branches diverge), he advanced the thesis: the common link is the actual creator of the hadith or its first wide disseminator, not a neutral transmitter. Chains above the common link were retroactively extended toward earlier authorities — up to the Messenger. The *e silentio* argument: if the hadith existed in the Messenger's era, it would have been cited in early legal debates recorded by jurists of the 1st–2nd centuries AH; its absence from citation indicates later origin.

G.H.A. Juynboll in *Muslim Tradition* (1983) and *Encyclopedia of Canonical Hadith* (2007) systematised the common link method (Juynboll 1983: 206–217) using spider diagrams and introduced additional concepts: partial common link (PCL), diving strand, single strand. Juynboll was more cautious: for him the common link is the person who first widely disseminated the hadith, not necessarily its creator. However, single strands above the common link he regarded as practically devoid of evidential force.

2.2. The Revisionist School

From the 1990s a revisionist tendency took shape, challenging the extreme scepticism of the Schacht school without reverting to traditional apologetics. The central figure is Harald Motzki. His method of isnād-cum-matn analysis (ICMA), presented in *The Origins of Islamic Jurisprudence* (2002) (Motzki 2002: 1–46) and in a series of articles, is based on the following logic: if different isnād branches going from a single common link carry systematically differing variants of the matn that correlate with the branches, this indicates real rather than fictitious transmission — a forger would have standardised the text rather than varying it systematically. Applying the method to *Muṣannaf ‘Abd al-Razzāq*, Motzki dated a number of traditions to the first century AH.

Gregor Schoeler in *The Oral and the Written in Early Islam* (2006) and *The Genesis of Literature in Islam* (2009) showed (Schoeler 2006: 28–56) that the early Islamic culture of transmission operated in a 'semi-oral' mode (hypomnema): written records existed from an early period as mnemonic supports, but oral transmission had authoritative status. This entails

a conclusion significant for textology: the concept of a single authorial original (Urtext) applied to hadith collections is conceptually problematic, not merely factually unattainable. A critical edition in the Western philological sense — as a reconstruction of a single archetypal text — is not merely absent here but in principle difficult to produce: the object of reconstruction (a stable written archetype) did not exist in the period of primary transmission. This means that variant readings between manuscripts may reflect not scribal errors but legitimate variants of oral performance.

Andreas Görke extended the application of ICMA in a series of articles, showing the possibility of reconstructing early narrative traditions (Görke and Schoeler 2005: 209–220).

2.3. The Position of the Present Study

This monograph aligns itself with neither the Schacht school nor the Motzki school as such. Its analytical position is determined differently: it establishes a limit that is common to both schools. Even with full acceptance of ICMA results — in the most optimistic interpretation of Motzki — the method permits dating a hadith to the level of the common link, but does not provide independent verification of the stage from the primary source to the common link. This segment, as a rule, constitutes a single strand — an isolated thread devoid of matn variability on which ICMA is inapplicable. It is precisely here that the entire irremovable uncertainty of the system is concentrated.

Critically: the problem does not lie in the length of the unverified segment. Even a single transition — from the nearest transmitter to the primary source — in the complete absence of external data about that transition, is structurally indistinguishable from a chain of seven links: in both cases P(correctness of retrospective reconstruction) remains fundamentally undetermined. The scale of the gap does not alter the architectural property of the system.

In other words: ICMA pushes the lower boundary of provability into an earlier period, but does not eliminate the structural gap between the common link and the primary source. The monograph's thesis remains unchanged regardless of the outcome of this debate.

The position of apologetic realism in Western scholarship was most consistently represented by Muḥammad Muṣṭafā al-ʿAzamī (al-Azami 1978: 11–34). Relying on papyrological data and early manuscript fragments, he argued for early written fixation of hadiths and criticised the argumentation of Schacht and Juynboll as built on *e silentio* — on the absence of sources rather than on the presence of counter-evidence. These arguments are significant, but their subject matter is limited: al-ʿAzamī demonstrates that early written fixation took place — which this monograph does not deny. The fundamental problem lies elsewhere: the existence of early records does not eliminate the absence of independent verification that these records genuinely trace back to the attributed source. A manuscript records the claim of transmission; it does not verify the transmission itself. Al-ʿAzamī's work thus shifts the discussion on the dating of fixation but does not touch the epistemological core of the monograph's thesis.

2.4. The Limit of ICMA: What the Method Proves and What Is Structurally Unattainable

The isnād-cum-matn analysis (ICMA) method remains the most serious analytical instrument in the arsenal of contemporary Western hadith studies. Its logic merits detailed examination: if different isnād branches going from a single common link carry systematically differing matn variants, this indicates real transmission — a forger would have standardised the text rather than varying it systematically. Applying ICMA to Muṣannaf ʿAbd al-Razzāq, Motzki dated a number of traditions to the first century AH (Motzki 2002: 1–46). Görke and Schoeler showed the possibility of reconstructing early narrative traditions to the level of the Companions (Görke and Schoeler 2005: 209–220). These results are accepted by this monograph in their entirety.

What ICMA proves. The method permits establishing: (1) the existence of a common link — the transmitter from whom several branches diverge; (2) the dating of a hadith to this transmitter with a high degree of confidence; (3) the identification of idrāj — later

interpolations — when variability between branches is sufficient (as in the case of the flag hadith, ch. 5.3). In the best scenario ICMA provides reliable historical depth: the given hadith was already circulating widely in the given period.

What ICMA does not prove — even in the most optimistic scenario. The method is inapplicable to a single strand — an isolated thread without parallel branches. Precisely such is the segment from the common link to the primary source: the first chain from a Companion to the common link is practically always a single strand on which matn variability is not recorded and ICMA is inapplicable. The first hadith of Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī (the hadith on intentions) is gharīb — the chain remains isolated until Yaḥyā ibn Saʿīd. The hadith on the fly has a common link — ʿUtba ibn Muslim — but the segment from Abū Hurayra to ʿUtba is a single strand through Ubayd ibn Ḥunayn. That is, even in the most favourable cases ICMA reaches the boundary of the common link — and goes no further.

The fundamental reason for this limitation is not technical: matn variability arises at the moment of branching of the chain downward from the common link. Before branching, variants of the matn in different branches simply do not exist — the text is unified and the branches have not yet diverged. This is not a defect of the method — it is an architectural property of the transmission system: the common link is the earliest node accessible to the instrument. The segment above it remains beyond the reach of any instrumental analysis — not only ICMA but any method that relies on variability or comparison of branches. ICMA advances the boundary of the provable forward — this is a significant contribution to hadith scholarship. But the monograph's thesis remains unchanged: the common link is the boundary of the attainable, not the primary source.

PART II. HADITH SCHOLARSHIP AS AN INSTITUTION

Chapter 3. The Institutional Contour of the System

3.1. What Is an Institution of Knowledge

The concept of 'institution' is used in this work in the sense developed by the sociology of knowledge and science studies: a stable system of practices, roles, norms, legitimation mechanisms, and reproduction that maintains a certain social order. With respect to knowledge — the order of production, authorization, and transmission of claims.

Hadith scholarship is an institution in this sense: it produces authoritative claims (hadiths), certifies them through the procedures of isnād and rijāl, forms a normative corpus through canonization, reproduces the system through education (ijāza), and maintains consensus through biographical dictionaries and the commentarial tradition. Analysing hadith scholarship as an institution rather than merely a methodology makes it possible to pose questions impossible from within: who produces authority; how the canon is formed; how the reputational filter operates; how the institution compensates for the absence of external verification.

3.2. The Isnād: Structure and Function

The isnād — a named list of transmitters from the current recorder to the presumed primary source — performs a dual function in the system: attributive (it connects the report to an authority) and verifying (it declares an unbroken chain of transmission). Epistemically crucial: the isnād is a retrospective report about transmission. The entire chain is formed at the moment of late recording and reflects the last link's knowledge of its predecessors. This is not a direct registration of an act of transmission, but a claim about it.

The consequence: the reliability of the entire construction is concentrated in the last link. The last transmitter does not merely pass on information — he constitutes the object of analysis. Before the moment of fixation the hadith does not exist as a verifiable source. This structural

fact is not a defect — it is the condition of possibility of the system. But it equally determines the system's epistemic limitations.

3.3. 'Ilm al-Rijāl: Reliability Assessment

'Ilm al-rijāl — the science of transmitters — is charged with establishing whether a given transmitter is capable of being a reliable link in the chain. Two parameters are assessed: 'adāla (moral uprightness, honesty) and ḍabt (accuracy of reproduction — either memory or written record). Both parameters are established not through observation of the act of transmission itself, but through reports by others about the transmitter's reputation. This means: the system for assessing a witness's reliability is itself based on testimonial evidence — testimony about a witness.

The classical biographical dictionaries (Tārīkh Ibn Maʿīn, Ṭabaqāt Ibn Saʿd, al-Jarḥ wa-l-Taʿdīl Ibn Abī Ḥātim, Tahdhīb al-Tahdhīb Ibn Ḥajar) summarise these assessments. The authors of the dictionaries — Ibn Maʿīn (d. 233/848), Ibn Saʿd (d. 230/845), Ibn Abī Ḥātim (d. 327/938) — form judgements about transmitters whose lives preceded them by one to two generations. These judgements are based on the oral tradition of evaluations functioning within the same transmitting milieu. No independent external data about concrete acts of transmission exist at any level.

The chronological failure of 'ilm al-rijāl in principle. 'Ilm al-rijāl as a systematic discipline took shape in the 3rd–4th centuries AH. Hadiths began to be recorded and transmitted in the 1st–2nd centuries. The instrument of verification appeared one to two generations after the object of verification had already formed. One can verify a present witness: observe, question, check the record. To reconstruct the reputation of a deceased person through the oral tradition of the same circle is a different operation with a different epistemic status. The moment when verification was possible — while the participants in the first-generation chains were still alive — the instrument did not yet exist. By the moment it was created, there was no one left to verify. This is not a deficiency of effort — it is a principled impossibility arising from chronology: the instrument appeared after the object.

'Ilm al-rijāl assesses not the fact of transmission but reputation. Reputation and the fact of transmission are different objects. A transmitter may be judged reliable by reputational criteria and yet conscientiously reproduce what he himself heard inaccurately. The system does not distinguish these two cases. This is precisely the second structural limitation, independent of the first: even if the system worked flawlessly, it would still verify not the fact of transmission but the reputation of the transmitter in the later tradition.

3.4. The Mechanism of Authority Formation

Authority in the hadith scholarship system is produced through a hierarchy of recognition: a high-ranking assessor (ḥāfīz, muḥaddith, imām) establishes an evaluation of a transmitter, which is then consolidated by citation in the dictionaries of subsequent generations. The key property: authority is not derived from independent verification — it is itself a product of recognition within the system. The high status of an assessor reinforces trust in his judgement but adds no verifiable data. This is a reputational, not an epistemic, procedure.

The consequence: the system possesses high internal stability (reliable transmitters are consistently marked as reliable, unreliable ones are rejected), but this stability does not translate into independent verification: it is a product of prolonged standardisation, not the result of checking against external data.

3.5. Canonization of the Corpus as an Institutional Process

The formation of the canon of al-Kutub al-Sitta — the six 'sound books' — is a historical process that was completed by the 6th–7th centuries AH. The collections of al-Bukhārī and Muslim received the status of the 'two Ṣaḥīḥs' by the 4th century, but the definitive list of six with the inclusion of Ibn Māja (instead of the Muwaṭṭa' or the Sunan of al-Dārimī) was established considerably later.

It should be noted that the analytical corpus in this monograph is limited to the six collections in their canonical composition as of the period of completion of canonization (6th–7th centuries AH). The Sunan of al-Dārimī, alternatively included by some authorities instead of Ibn Māja, is not included in the analysis for the following reasons: its manuscript base in available catalogues is considerably inferior to the six canonical collections; its normative status is unstable across legal schools; its inclusion or exclusion does not alter any of the four analytical levels of the monograph, since the structural properties of the institution — self-referentiality, retrospectivity, correlation, absence of critical editions — characterise al-Dārimī equally.

This process is institutional selection by intra-systemic criteria: the degree of recognition of authors, rijāl standards, and breadth of distribution across legal schools. Canonization is not verification: the recognition of a collection within the tradition testifies to the success of institutional selection, but does not prove the authenticity of its content. This distinction is fundamental: it defines what happened — texts recognised as normative were formed — and what did not happen — their historical origin was not independently verified.

3.6. Matn Criticism: A Compatibility Filter

Matn criticism — analysis of a hadith's content — is directed toward identifying obvious discrepancies: contradictions with the Quran, the basic hadith corpus, rational-legal norms, or linguistic standards. It is a compatibility filter: it excludes reports incompatible with the normative system. It is not an instrument for proving authenticity: a report's conformity with the system's expectations may be the result of either genuine transmission or the successful integration of later texts into the corpus. Matn criticism does not distinguish these cases.

PART III. STRUCTURAL VULNERABILITIES OF THE SYSTEM

Chapter 4. Self-Referentiality as an Evidential Problem

4.1. The Closed Verificatory Circle

The central structural vulnerability of hadith scholarship consists in the following: all elements of the evidential apparatus are certified within one and the same tradition. The scheme of the closed circle: the isnād is confirmed by the reliability of transmitters; the reliability of transmitters is established by 'ilm al-rijāl; the authority of the sources of 'ilm al-rijāl is confirmed by other sources from the same tradition; the manuscripts of these sources have been preserved through the same transmitting system; the authors of the manuscripts are verified through the same biographical dictionaries. There are no external anchors at any level of this chain.

This is not mere 'closure' in the broad sense (which is inherent to any normative system), but a structural impossibility of exiting the circle without an external archive. An external archive is something that is principally absent: independent documentary testimonies about transmitters, administrative records, dated papyri with the names of transmitters in their role as hadith transmitters — no systematic external data permitting independent verification of concrete acts of transmission have been found. The institution, which is charged with proving the authenticity of information, has no externally verifiable foundation for its own evidential apparatus.

The failure of the system's declaration. The system claims: the isnād certifies that the given report genuinely traces back to the Messenger. What it actually produces: the given report is recognised as normative within the tradition that formed in the 3rd–4th centuries AH. These are not the same thing. Recognition within the tradition and authentic delivery from the primary source are two different claims. The system proves the first and declares the second. The gap between declaration and result is not an external critique but an internal contradiction: the system itself formulates its task as the verification of a historical fact of transmission (Ibn aṣ-Ṣalāḥ, al-Khaṭīb al-Baghdādī), yet is structurally incapable of performing it.

4.2. Testimony about a Witness: Recursive Structure

The mechanism of *‘ilm al-rijāl* is built on the principle of testimony about a witness: the reliability of transmitter A is established on the basis of transmitter B's reports about A's personal qualities. B in turn is assessed through C. The object of analysis is not the act of transmission itself but the reputation of its participant. This is a fundamentally different object from the event the system is supposed to certify.

In analytical epistemology this is designated as second-order testimony: testimony about the reliability of a primary witness, which is itself a testimony. The reliability of second-order testimony depends on the same conditions as the reliability of primary testimony — above all, on independence from the same milieu that forms dispositions toward accepting some reports and rejecting others. In the hadith system the second order and the first order belong to the same milieu: no assessor of transmitters is an external observer.

4.3. Retrospectivity: Accumulated Uncertainty

All information about the early links of the transmission chain is formed retrospectively — through a significant temporal interval after the presumed events. Biographical data about transmitters of the first generation (*ṣaḥāba*) are reconstructed by authors of the 3rd–4th centuries AH; data about transmitters of the second generation (*tābi‘ūn*) by authors of the 4th–5th centuries. The interval between a transmitter's life and first biographical fixation spans one to three generations.

Retrospectivity means accumulated uncertainty: each intermediate step adds the possibility of distortion, simplification, or standardisation. With the good faith of all participants these processes are still systematic: memory unifies details, narrative simplifies complex chains, the milieu forms expectations to which transmission adjusts. This is not an accusation of deliberate deception — it is a description of cognitive and social mechanisms inevitable in multi-step retrospective reconstruction.

4.4. Correlation instead of Independence

The multiplicity of parallel transmissions is treated in the tradition as the strongest argument in favour of reliability: if the same hadith is transmitted through many independent chains, the probability of collusion or error decreases. This argument holds when chains are independent. In the hadith system this condition is as a rule not met. Transmitters belong to common educational circles and schools (*ḥalaqāt*), use the same formulae of transmission, orient themselves toward a single normative authority, and were educated by common teachers.

In probability theory this is called correlated evidence from a common cause: the apparent multiplicity of testimonies is explained by a common cause (the common formative milieu), not by independent observation. Under such conditions multiplying the number of chains increases the coherence of the corpus but does not reduce uncertainty about the source.

Critically: this argument does not assert that correledness testifies to fabrication. It registers the structural indistinguishability of two interpretations — a common milieu and a common source — in the absence of independent external data. It is precisely this indistinguishability, not a conclusion about fabrication, that constitutes the epistemic limitation.

4.5. The Mutawātir Category: The Limit of the Strongest Argument

Mutawātir — a hadith transmitted by so large a number of transmitters at every level that their collusion is deemed impossible — is the highest degree of proof within the tradition, generating *‘ilm ḍarūrī* (necessary knowledge). The criterion is directed against deliberate collusion.

Epistemic analysis reveals: mutawātir does not resolve the problem of the common formative milieu. Even without collusion, transmitters acting in a unified normative milieu apply common criteria of acceptability, are educated by common teachers, and orient themselves toward a unified corpus. Multiplicity within a common milieu is correlatedness, not independence. Moreover, historically most hadiths that received mutawātir status in later

classifications display a single strand at the earliest levels of transmission: multiplicity emerges at the level of the second or third generation, not from the first moment.

This conclusion is unaffected by the possible objection about regional dispersion: even if one accepts that seventy Companions who transmitted the hadith on deliberate lying acted in different regions (Iraq, Syria, Egypt, Medina), this does not eliminate the problem of a common milieu. The criteria of hadith acceptability and the canons of reputation were formed in a common educational environment and through common teachers before the regional divergence of chains. Regional dispersion does not create epistemic independence if the common normative milieu was formed before that divergence.

Chapter 5. Empirical Analysis: Four Hadiths

5.1. The Hadith on Intentions

The four hadiths below are selected by the criterion of normative significance within the tradition itself: each occupies an exceptional position in the canonical discourse (al-Bukhārī, Muslim, Abū Dāwūd), and it is precisely for this reason that their manuscript and isnād situations constitute the most representative test of the monograph's theses. The purpose of the analysis is not to refute these hadiths as such, but to show that high normative status does not compensate for the absence of independent verification of the transmission chain.

"Deeds are judged only by intentions" (innamā al-a'māl bi-l-niyyāt). Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī №1. Isnād: al-Ḥumaydī — Sufyān — Yahyā ibn Sa'īd al-Anṣārī — Muḥammad ibn Ibrāhīm al-Taymī — 'Alqama ibn Waqqāṣ al-Laythī — 'Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb — the Messenger.

This hadith — the first in the most authoritative Sunni collection — is gharīb: its chain remains isolated (single strand) throughout until Yahyā ibn Sa'īd, where it first branches. Until branching, all information about the chain comes exclusively from one link. The ICMA method is inapplicable to a single strand in principle: there are no parallel branches, and matn variability is not recorded. One of the normatively most significant hadiths in the entire corpus displays the structural limitation of the system in its most exposed form.

5.2. The Hadith on the Fly

"If a fly falls into the drink of any of you, let him submerge it entirely and then remove it: for in one of its wings is a disease, and in the other a remedy" (Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, №3320). Application of ICMA (Mufid, Sattar, Rifai, 2023) established the common link: 'Utba ibn Muslim (d. c. 120/738). Three documented branches of transmission diverge from him. The segment from Abū Hurayra to 'Utba is a single strand through Ubayd ibn Ḥunayn.

ICMA permits confidently dating the hadith to 'Utba ibn Muslim. The segment Abū Hurayra → 'Utba (~50–70 years, the first generation after the Messenger's death) constitutes a single strand: the method is unavailable, and there is no independent verification. This is a structurally necessary limitation: the sole path to the primary source is in principle inaccessible to instrumental analysis.

5.3. The Hadiths on the Messenger's Flag

The study by Muiz Amir et al. (2021) applied ICMA to the corpus of hadiths about the tawhid inscription on the Messenger's banner. The established common link — Ḥayyān ibn 'Ubaydallāh — is a 2nd-century AH transmitter active in Egypt during the period of acute Abbasid-Umayyad rivalry. The authors identify the tawhid inscription as idrāj — a late interpolation into the hadith corpus made in the context of political propaganda.

This case is significant in two respects. First, ICMA shows that late interpolations are detectable when sufficient variability exists: the presence of several branches permits identifying the anomaly. Second, it shows the structural limitation: had the interpolation been made before the branching point, it would have been methodologically indistinguishable from original content. The instrument's capabilities are determined by the isnād configuration, which is itself not independent of the system's data.

5.4. The Hadith on Deliberate Falsehood (Mutawātir)

"Whoever lies about me intentionally, let him prepare his place in the Fire" (man kadhaba 'alayya muta'ammidan fa-l-yatabawwa' maq'adah min al-nār). One of the few hadiths classified as mutawātir: it is transmitted from more than seventy Companions according to classical compilations. This is the strongest intra-systemic argument in favour of reliability.

Epistemic analysis: the information that a specific Companion transmitted this hadith comes from a tābi'ī — a second-generation transmitter. There is no direct testimony about the act of transmission at the ṣaḥāba level: it is mediated. Multiplicity at the ṣaḥāba level is reconstructed retrospectively through multiplicity at the tābi'ūn level. The branching occurs not at the first moment but a level later. The mutawātir status does not remove the problem of retrospective mediation: it establishes the wide circulation of the hadith by the third generation but does not provide independent access to the first. The strongest intra-systemic argument does not overcome the structural limitation.

Chapter 6. The System of Counter-Arguments and Their Refutation

6.1. 'A Foreign Standard Is Being Applied to Hadiths'

Argument: the criteria of strict proof are Western, positivist, inapplicable to a different rationality. Refutation: the argument splits into two theses. The first — the autonomy of hadith-studies rationality — is methodologically admissible and acknowledged by this work: internal-traditional reliability has its own standards and operates in its own sphere. The second thesis — that this autonomous rationality is sufficient to ground historical authenticity — is untenable: as soon as the system claims to make a statement about a fact of historical reality ('the Messenger actually said this'), it automatically enters the domain where universal criteria of source independence apply. Autonomy cannot be a shield against epistemics when the system itself advances historical claims.

This distinction requires separate clarification with respect to the position of reformed epistemology. Plantinga (Plantinga 1993: 179–237) developed arguments in favour of the view that religious beliefs may be basic — i.e. epistemically warranted without derivation from other beliefs and without external verification. This argument is accepted by this monograph as methodologically admissible with respect to normative religious beliefs. However, it does not extend to the situation of the present study: the monograph analyses not a basic religious belief ('God exists', 'revelation is genuine'), but the specific institutional claim of the system to the historical delivery of information — a claim the tradition itself formulates in historical, not faith-based, terms. It is precisely this distinction that defines the subject matter of the monograph: not the grounds of religious faith, but the evidential architecture of historical attribution.

6.2. 'Ancient Sources Are Always Retrospective'

Argument: all historical research on antiquity is based on late sources; the same standard is applied to hadiths. Refutation: historical source studies does indeed work with late sources — but compensates for this with external corroboration: archival documents, epigraphy, numismatics, external chronicles. The fundamental difference of the hadith system lies not in the lateness of the sources but in the principled absence of external correlates for transmitters and their assessors. This makes retrospectivity not a forced circumstance but a structural feature.

6.3. 'Multiplicity of Testimonies Is Probabilistically Sufficient'

Argument: with a sufficient number of independent chains the probability of common error or collusion is negligible. Refutation: the probabilistic argument works only when there is independence. In Bayesian terms: if $P(E_1|H)$ and $P(E_2|H)$ are correlated through a common cause C (the common milieu), then $P(H|E_1 \wedge E_2) \neq P(H|E_1) \times P(H|E_2)/P(H)$. The common learning environment, common authorities, and common criteria of acceptability constitute precisely

such a common cause. Multiplicity without independence is correlated coherence, not independent confirmation.

It is necessary, however, to register the limit of this argument itself. The thesis about the correlatedness of testimonies is demonstrable under the condition that the common normative milieu actively shaped the content of transmission. An alternative interpretation is possible: if transmitters reproduced what they actually heard, the correlation is explained not by a common cause (the milieu) but by a common source (genuine transmission). The monograph does not provide a means of distinguishing these two cases at the level of probabilistic argumentation — the independent data necessary for this are principally absent. It is precisely this absence that is key: the problem is not that correlatedness proves fabrication, but that in the absence of independent data it is impossible to determine which of the two interpretations is correct. The indistinguishability of the two interpretations in the absence of an external archive is the structural limitation of the system.

The limit of this argument must be noted. Bayesian epistemology (Bovens and Hartmann, *Bayesian Epistemology*, 2003) shows that partially correlated testimonies still make a non-zero contribution to posterior probability, provided the degree of correlation is known. The principled limitation of the hadith system consists precisely in the fact that the degree of correlation cannot in principle be assessed from external data: the absence of external data remains structural, independently of the degree of correlation.

6.4. 'The System Has Passed a Millennium of Testing'

Argument: the longevity of the system's functioning testifies to its reliability. Refutation: longevity of functioning testifies to institutional stability, but not to epistemic reliability in the sense of historical verification. Normative systems may be functionally stable without being historically verified — this is registered in any comparative work on institutions of law and religion.

6.5. Conclusion

None of the counter-arguments examined eliminates the three structural limitations: absence of independent sources, impossibility of external verification of early links, and the logical circle in reputational assessment. Each counter-argument either shifts the level of analysis (moving from historical authenticity to internal-traditional reliability) or directly reproduces the registered limitations.

PART IV. THE MANUSCRIPT BASE

Chapter 7. Chronological Gaps, the Physical Corpus, and the Absence of Independent Dating

7.1. The General State of the Manuscript Tradition

The manuscript tradition of the six canonical hadith collections is characterised by three features that are fundamentally important for epistemic analysis. First, no autograph — a manuscript written in the author's own hand — has been preserved for any of the six collections. Second, the earliest surviving manuscripts are dated considerably later than the presumed time of composition — the gap ranges from 100 to 445 years depending on the collection and type of manuscript. Third, no hadith manuscript has been subjected to published radiocarbon analysis, whereas Quranic manuscripts have been subjected to such analysis on multiple occasions.

These facts do not 'refute' the tradition in themselves: the absence of early manuscripts does not prove the absence of an early text — medieval manuscripts were not preserved under archival conditions. What is fundamentally different: in the absence of autographs and synchronous independent documents, all information about the text and its transmission comes

through the same system that is supposed to be verified. The manuscript base does not eliminate the problem of self-referentiality — it reproduces it at the level of physical carriers.

7.2. Summary Table of Gaps

Collection	Author's Death	Earliest Fragment	Gap (fr.)	Complete MS	Gap (comp.)
Muwaṭṭa' of Mālik	179/795	~200/~815	~21 yrs	3rd–4th c. AH	~100–150 yrs
Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī	256/870	4th c. AH / 10th c.	~100–150 yrs	5th c. / 11th c.	~200 yrs
Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim	261/875	4th–5th c. AH	~90–200 yrs	5th c. / 11th c.	~150–240 yrs
Sunan Abī Dāwūd	275/889	late 3rd–4th c. AH	~25–75 yrs	5th c.	~125–225 yrs
Jāmi' al-Tirmidhī	279/892	late 4th–early 5th c.	~100–150 yrs	6th–7th c.	~200–300 yrs
Sunan al-Nasā'ī	303/915	late 4th c.	~70–120 yrs	5th–6th c.	~150–250 yrs
Sunan Ibn Māja	273/887	~5th c. AH	~130–200 yrs	6th c.	~250–350 yrs
Al-Yūnīnī recension (Bukhārī standard)	256/870	—	—	701/1302	445 years

Sources: Muranji (1984, 1997); Brown (2007); catalogues: Süleymaniye Kütüphanesi, Chester Beatty Library, Dār al-Kutub al-Miṣriyya.

7.3. Early Fragments: What Exists and Why It Is Insufficient

The existence of early fragments — above all the Kairouan fragments of the Muwaṭṭa' (~815 CE), discovered and published by Miklós Muranyi (University of Bonn) — is a real fact of the manuscript tradition and must not be denied. The gap of ~21 years for these fragments is considerably smaller than for other collections. Similarly, Chester Beatty Library, Dublin (MS Ar. 3609) holds one of the early partial copies of Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, dated ~5th century AH.

The fundamental argument: an early fragment is not an independent external witness, since its attribution — who wrote it, from whom it was received, through which transmission line — comes through an isnād belonging to the same system. The Kairouan fragments of the Muwaṭṭa' are identified as belonging to the recension of Yaḥyā ibn Yaḥyā al-Laythī or Ibn Bukayr — through isnāds going from Mālik's students. The physical existence of an early manuscript and the independent verification of its attribution are fundamentally different things. An early fragment documents early existence of the text in a given recensional line, but does not eliminate dependence on the system itself.

The Ṣaḥīfa of Hammām ibn Munabbih — the collection held in the Staatsbibliothek Berlin (MS Or. Oct. 1383) and traditionally dated by the Islamic tradition to the 1st–2nd centuries AH — requires separate consideration. This document is the most frequently cited apologetic evidence for early written fixation of hadiths. The analysis reproduces the general scheme. The physical dating of the Staatsbibliothek manuscript is ~3rd–4th centuries AH — that is, 150–250 years after the presumed composition by Hammām ibn Munabbih (d. c. 101/719). No radiocarbon analysis of the manuscript has been conducted. Attribution of the document to Hammām ibn Munabbih comes through the isnāds of the Islamic biographical tradition; there is no independent external confirmation of authorship. The Ṣaḥīfa records the early existence of hadith recording protocols — which the monograph does not deny. It does not eliminate the structural argument: attribution of the physical manuscript to a specific author is carried out through the same system whose independence is the object of analysis.

7.4. Authors of Collections: Absence of External Verification

The biographies of all six canonical compilers — al-Bukhārī (d. 256/870), Muslim (d. 261/875), Abū Dāwūd (d. 275/889), al-Tirmidhī (d. 279/892), al-Nasā'ī (d. 303/915), and Ibn Māja (d. 273/887) — are known exclusively from Islamic biographical dictionaries. Not a single epigraphic, numismatic, papyrological, or non-Islamic documentary testimony has been found that directly confirms the existence of any of these persons in their role as compilers of hadith collections.

The earliest independent mentions of al-Bukhārī's works (in Abū Bakr al-Ismā'īlī, d. 371/981, and al-Dāraqūṭnī, d. 385/995) and the bibliographic entry in Ibn al-Nadīm's *Kitāb al-Fihrist* (c. 377/987) stand 100–127 years from the author's death and are themselves part of the Islamic literary tradition. This does not prove the non-existence of the compilers: it registers that their activity in the role of hadith collection compilers is not verified independently of the same tradition they are supposed to certify.

The analogous situation applies to key transmitters — Abū Hurayra, Ibn 'Abbās, 'Ā'isha, Anas ibn Mālik — none of whom is mentioned in any non-Islamic source specifically in their role as hadith transmitters. A partial exception consists of figures who played political roles (al-Zuhrī and his connection to the Umayyad court), but no non-Islamic source confirms their hadith activity.

7.5. Manuscripts of Biographical Dictionaries

Work	Author (d.)	Earliest MS	Gap
Tārīkh Ibn Ma'īn	233/848	~6th c. AH (12th c.)	~350–400 yrs
Ṭabaqāt Ibn Sa'd	230/845	~5th c. AH (11th c.)	~250–300 yrs
Tārīkh al-Kabīr (al-Bukhārī)	256/870	~5th–6th c. AH	~250–350 yrs
al-Jarḥ wa-l-Ta'dīl (Ibn Abī Ḥātim)	327/938	~6th–7th c. AH	~250–350 yrs
Muṣannaf 'Abd al-Razzāq	211/827	~5th c. AH (11th c.)	~250–300 yrs
Tahdhīb al-Kamāl (al-Mizzī)	742/1341	~8th c. AH (14th c.)	~0–50 yrs
Tahdhīb al-Tahdhīb (Ibn Ḥajar)	852/1449	~9th c. AH (15th c.)	~0 yrs

The instrument charged with verifying the reliability of hadith transmitters has survived in manuscripts standing 250–400 years from their authors. Verification of the verification instrument proceeds through the same system — the circle closes at the second level.

7.6. Radiocarbon Dating: The Fundamental Lacuna

Radiocarbon dating has not been applied to the manuscripts of the six canonical hadith collections in any published systematic study. This contrasts with the Quranic tradition, for which several well-documented C14 studies have been conducted: Birmingham fragment (Mingana Islamic Arabic 1572a): C14 dating by the University of Birmingham — 568–645 CE (95.4% confidence); Ṣan'ā' palimpsest (DAM 01-27.1): Sadeghi and Goudarzi, *Der Islam* 87 (2012) — dating of the lower layer to ~671 CE; Tübingen fragment (Ma VI 165): dating to 649–675 CE.

Systematic application of C14 to early hadith manuscripts — above all to the Kairouan fragments of the *Muwatta'* and the Damascus *ajzā'* — would permit independent establishment of the dating of physical carriers, eliminating dependence on palaeographic assessments with a margin of error of ±50–100 years. Until such analysis is conducted, all dating of hadith manuscripts remains functionally dependent on the same traditional system of attribution they should independently verify.

7.7. Geography of the Corpus: Dispersal without a Catalogue

Repository	Country	Estimate (MSS of 6 collections)	Note
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Süleymaniye Kütüphanesi	Turkey	500–1000+	Largest single repository; primarily 14th–19th c.
Dār al-Kutub al-Miṣriyya	Egypt	160–340	Access through bureaucratic channels
Chester Beatty Library	Ireland	10–35	MS Ar. 3609 — early Bukhārī ~5th c. AH
Staatsbibliothek Berlin	Germany	30–75	Ṣaḥīfa of Hammām ibn Munabbih (~3rd c. AH)
British Library	UK	45–110	Open to researchers
BnF Paris	France	25–60	Open; Fonds Arabe
Biblioteca Qarawiyyīn	Morocco	40–130	Practically closed to outsiders
Assad National Library	Syria	70–170	△ Status after Dec. 2024 unknown
Raqqāda / Kairouan	Tunisia	15–55	Early Muwaṭṭaʾ fragments; access via INP

Dispersal means: no attempt at complete collation of manuscripts can be considered complete without access to holdings, some of which are closed, difficult to access, or in a zone of uncertainty. This is a structural limitation of the textological infrastructure, not a temporary technical problem.

PART V. THE TEXTOLOGICAL INADEQUACY OF THE INSTITUTION

Chapter 8. The Absence of Critical Editions

8.1. What a Critical Edition Is and Why It Matters

A critical edition in the Western philological tradition is an edition based on: (1) systematic inventory of all known manuscripts with assignment of unique sigla; (2) complete collation of their texts with registration of all variant readings; (3) construction of a stemma — a genealogical tree of the manuscript tradition; (4) selection of a base text on the basis of explicit principles, with a full apparatus of alternative readings; (5) a praefatio describing the manuscript tradition, methodology, and manuscript base.

None of the six canonical hadith collections has a critical edition in this sense. Why this matters: every academic claim about the content of a hadith implicitly relies on a text whose fidelity to the manuscript tradition has not been established by contemporary methods. When Motzki conducts ICMA, he works with texts from printed editions based on a limited manuscript base. When Juynboll builds theories about the common link, he operates with isnāds from those same unverified editions. The epistemic problem registered in Part III is reproduced at the level of the text: what the system transmits is itself not established.

8.2. 'Standard' Editions and Their Limitations

The situation with each collection is heterogeneous, but the general conclusion is the same. Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī is the most studied and most complex case. Three editions compete for the status of 'standard'. The Sulṭānī edition (Cairo, Būlāq, 1311–1313/1893–1895) is based on al-Yūnīnī's collation (d. 701/1302) — a medieval 'quasi-critical' apparatus that compared several lines of transmission. The Krehl–Juynboll edition (Leiden, Brill, 4 vols., 1862–1908) is based on a narrow manuscript base from European libraries — it became the standard in Western academia solely by virtue of its accessibility. The Dār Ṭawq al-Najāt edition (ed. al-Nāṣir, 2001) relies directly on the al-Yūnīnī manuscript. None of the three has a stemma or transparent methodology. All three diverge not only in isnāds but in matn formulations.

Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim: standard — Fuʿād ʿAbd al-Bāqī edition (Cairo, 1955–56, 5 vols.), which introduced continuous numbering; no proper critical edition exists. Sunan Abī Dāwūd: long standard — ʿAbd al-Ḥamīd (Cairo, 1935), now al-Arnāʾuṭ (Dār al-Risāla, 2009); no stemma. Jāmiʿ al-Tirmidhī: two competing editions — Shākir (Cairo, 1937–65) and Maʾrūf (Dār al-

Gharb al-Islāmī, 1998). Sunan al-Nasā'ī: Abū Ghudda (Aleppo, 1986). Sunan Ibn Māja: 'Abd al-Bāqī (Cairo, 1952–53).

8.3. Discrepancies in Matns: The Second Level of Textological Inadequacy

Jonathan Brown documents in detail the multiplicity of recensions of Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī (Brown 2007: 259–261): transmission through al-Firabī (d. 320/932) is primary, but recensions through al-Nasafī (d. 295/908), Ibn Ma'qil, and al-Ḥammawī also existed. Within al-Firabī's transmission, sub-recensions formed: through Abū Dharr al-Harawī, al-Aṣīlī, Abū l-Waqt, and Ibn 'Asākir. These recensions contain textual differences not only in isnāds but in the text of the matns themselves.

This is the second level of textological inadequacy, independent of the first. First level: the system cannot prove authentic transmission from the primary source. Second level: even the text it transmits is not established. Both levels are independent: refutation of one does not remove the other.

8.4. The Numbering Chaos as Symptom

No unified system for citing hadiths exists in Western academia. Three systems compete: the format of Wensinck's Concordance (Brill, 8 vols., 1933–88) — collection + kitāb + bāb; 'Abd al-Bāqī's numbering — continuous number; volume:page reference to an edition. For Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī at least three incompatible numbering systems coexist. The same matn receives different numbers depending on where it is placed in one or another chapter (since al-Bukhārī consciously repeated hadiths in different kitābs). The absence of unified numbering is not a technical inconvenience but a symptom of a fundamental problem: there is no single recognised text against which a standard could be built. This fundamentally distinguishes hadith scholarship from biblical studies, where the formula 'Book Chapter:Verse' is a universal standard independent of manuscript debates.

8.5. Textual Variability of Matns: The Empirical Level

The preceding paragraphs established the absence of critical editions and documented the multiplicity of competing recensions. This section moves from registering institutional gaps to empirical analysis: to what extent did matn content actually vary during transmission? The answer is based on published textological data for three corpora — the Muwaṭṭa' of Mālik, Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, and Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim — and represents the fifth independent analytical level of the monograph.

Methodological note: the data used come predominantly from apologetic sources whose purpose is to demonstrate the textual integrity of the hadith corpus. This makes them especially significant for the present analysis: facts of textual variability registered by defenders of the tradition cannot be dismissed as an artefact of critical bias. They are data acknowledged by the system itself.

I. Muwaṭṭa' of Mālik: Inter-Recensional Variability. The Muwaṭṭa' is the chronologically earliest canonical collection and possesses the most studied inter-recensional base. The collection was transmitted by Mālik's numerous students in variant versions: the tradition records up to thirty recensions, of which sixteen are considered sufficiently well transmitted (al-Ghāfiqī, cited in Muranyi 1997: 42; cf. Brown 2009: 19–20). Al-Ghāfiqī's quantitative analysis covers twelve versions of the Muwaṭṭa' and reveals the following: of the 666 hadiths present in the analysed corpus, 97 differ between versions in matn content — that is, 14.6% of hadiths display inter-recensional variability (al-Ghāfiqī, cited in Muranyi 1997: 45–48; cf. Brown 2009: 20). The recension of Aḥmad ibn Abī Bakr al-Zuhrī exceeds the recension of Yaḥyā ibn Yaḥyā al-Laythī (recognised as standard) in volume by 5–10%: the difference means not orthographic discrepancies but the presence in one version of hadiths absent in the other.

Table 8.5.1. Inter-Recensional Variability of the Muwaṭṭa' of Mālik

Recension	Hadiths (approx.)	Character of Differences
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Yahyā ibn Yahyā al-Laythī	~1800	Standard ('Vulgate'); basis of most editions
Muḥammad al-Shaybānī	~1015	Considerably shorter; emphasis on Ḥanafī interpretation
Aḥmad al-Zuhrī	~1900–1980	5–10% larger than al-Laythī; contains hadiths absent in al-Laythī
Ibn Wahb	~1400	Several matns textually closer to the Mudawwana than to al-Laythī
Abū Muṣ‘ab al-Zuhrī	~1500	Contains 64 traditions absent in al-Laythī (Ibn ‘Abd al-Barr)
Total diverging	97 of 666	14.6% inter-recensional matn variability (al-Ghāfiqī)

II. **Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī: Editorial Decisions of Transmitters as a Source of Variability.** Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī has the most ramified recensional tradition among the six canonical collections. The key fact, registered by apologetic literature and turning against its own conclusions: al-Bukhārī died before completing the final editing of the Ṣaḥīḥ, leaving some material in the margins and on separate sheets (Zaman 2024: 45–52; Brown 2007: 259–261). Four main students of al-Firabrī — al-Mustamlī, al-Sarakhsī, al-Kushmihānī, and al-Marwazī — independently decided where to place this material in the main text. This means: four recensions of one collection, tracing to one source — the manuscript of al-Firabrī — contain different arrangements of material not because of scribal errors but as a result of the transmitters' deliberate editorial decisions. Transmission here is not reproduction of a fixed text but interpretive activity.

Table 8.5.2. Main Recensions of Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī through al-Firabrī

Transmitter	Tradition	Textological Role
Al-Mustamlī (d. 376/986)	Samarqandian	Own arrangement of marginal material
Al-Sarakhsī (d. 381/991)	Khurasanian	Differs from al-Mustamlī in arrangement of sections
Al-Kushmihānī (d. 389/999)	Khurasanian	Forms basis of part of Istanbul manuscripts
Al-Marwazī (Abū Zayd, d. 371/981)	Egyptian-Andalusian	Via him — early MS ~360–390 AH; basis of al-Aṣīlī recension
Al-Yūnīnī (d. 701/1302)	Composite	Collation of five MSS; standard of Sulṭānī edition; 445 years after Bukhārī

III. **Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim: Variability through Recensional Lines.** Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim survives in no fewer than five hundred manuscripts copied over a millennium in different regions (Zaman / Yaqeen Institute, 2023). Analysis of 117 cases in the Ibn Māhān recension identified 36 errors or scribal corruptions — 30.8% of the checked corpus (Zaman / Yaqeen Institute 2023: §3.2). Four main recensional lines through al-Fārābī, Ibn Sifyān, Ibn Mūsā, and Ibn Māhān transmit the text with systematic inter-recensional differences; some lines did not preserve an unbroken audition chain and were transmitted only through ijāza — written permission without oral contact (al-Sakhāwī, cited in Zaman, 2023).

Table 8.5.3. Classification of Documented Types of Matn Variability

Type of Variability	Definition	Example	Significance for Matn
Structural	Hadith present in one recension and absent in another	Muwatta‘: 64 hadiths in Abū Muṣ‘ab vs. al-Laythī	High
Corpus	Different collection volume between recensions	Muwatta‘ al-Shaybānī ~1015 vs. al-Laythī ~1800	High
Compositional	Same material placed in different sections	Bukhārī: four students of al-Firabrī	Medium

Formulaic	Differences in matn text with same isnād	Bukhārī: recensions through al-Firabī; Muwaṭṭa': 97 of 666	Medium
Scribal	Errors and corruptions in copying	Muslim recension of Ibn Māhān: 36 of 117 cases	Low

The aggregate data for the three corpora permits formulating an empirically verifiable conclusion: the hadith system did not produce identical texts when transmitting through different recensional lines. The variability was structural in character — it affected not only orthography and vocalisation but the composition of the corpus (presence or absence of hadiths), the volume of the collection, and matn formulations. Transmitters made independent editorial decisions whose results diverged from each other and cannot be reduced to a single original.

This empirical observation is independent of and in addition to the four analytical levels of the monograph. Levels I–IV proved the impossibility of verifying transmission through the logic of the system. Level V registers: independently of whether transmission is verifiable, it did not in fact produce a stable text. An institution that declares the preservation of the primary source's words has documentarily registered the production of variant versions of those words — and did so in its own apologetic sources.

IV. Manuscript Base of the Six Canonical Collections: Summary Data

Table 8.5.4. Manuscript Base of the Kutub al-Sitta: Earliest Known Manuscripts and Chronological Gaps

Collection	Author / d.	Hadiths	Earliest MS	MS Date	Repository	Yrs from Author	Digitised
Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī	al-Bukhārī 256/870	7,563 (w/ rep.)	MS-BUL-1017 (kitābs 65–69)	408/1017	Nat. Lib. Bulgaria, Sofia	147	Yes (LOC WDL)
Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim	Muslim b. al-Ḥajjāj 261/875	7,500 (w/ rep.)	Khuda Bakhsh MS (partial)	d. 486/1093	Khuda Bakhsh Lib., Patna	~218	No
Sunan Abī Dāwūd	Abū Dāwūd 275/888	5,274 (w/ rep.)	Alexandria MS (pt. 3)	576/1180	Not established	292	No
Jāmi' al-Tirmidhī	al-Tirmidhī 279/892	4,400 (w/ rep.)	Leiden MS Or.	540/1145	Leiden Univ. Libraries	253	Yes (CC-BY)
Sunan al-Nasā'ī	al-Nasā'ī 303/915	5,758 (w/ rep.)	Khuda Bakhsh MSS (pts. 7–8)	d. 541/1144	Khuda Bakhsh Lib., Patna	~229	No
Sunan Ibn Māja	Ibn Māja 273/887	4,341 (w/ rep.)	MSS not earlier than 7th–8th c. AH	~13th–14th c.	Süleymaniye and Damascus	~400–500	No

Chapter 9. Comparison with Other Textual Disciplines

9.1. New Testament Textology

New Testament textology has the Nestle-Aland edition (NA28, 2012) based on the collation of ~5,800 Greek manuscripts — 130 papyri (some from the 2nd century CE), 320 majuscules, 2,900 minuscules, 2,400 lectionaries — plus data from early translations (Latin, Syriac, Coptic) and patristic citations. The apparatus records all significant variants per verse. Work is coordinated by the Institut für neutestamentliche Textforschung (INTF, Münster). The Coherence-Based Genealogical Method (CBGM) — computerised stemmatology — has been developed. The New Testament Virtual Manuscript Room (NTVMR) provides open online access to manuscript images and transcriptions.

9.2. Old Testament Textology

Old Testament textology has the Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia (BHS, 1977) based on the Leningrad Codex (1008/1009) and its successor Biblia Hebraica Quinta (BHQ, from 2004), incorporating evidence from the Qumran scrolls — manuscripts standing one thousand years earlier than the medieval corpus.

9.3. Classical Philology

Classical philology operates with Teubner editions (from 1849, now De Gruyter) and Oxford Classical Texts (from 1894). Each edition presupposes complete collation of manuscripts, construction of a stemma, apparatus criticus, and an extended praefatio. The Loeb Classical Library (Harvard UP, 530+ vols.) produces reader's, not critical, editions, but ones based on the best critical texts.

9.4. Summary Contrast

Criterion	NT Textology	OT Textology	Classical Philology	Hadith Scholarship
Critical edition	NA28 (2012)	BHS/BHQ	Teubner/OCT	Absent
Complete MS collation	~5,800	Complete + Qumran	Complete	Absent
Stemma	CBGM	Exists	Exists	Absent
Unified MS catalogue	NTVMR	Exists	Exists	Absent
Unified numbering	Chapter:Verse	Chapter:Verse	Lines/paragraphs	Three incompatible
C14 of early MSS	Yes	Yes (Qumran)	N/A	Absent
Research institute	INTF Münster	Several	Several	Absent
Corpus project	NTVMR	BHQ	TLG/PHI	Corpus Coranicum (Quran only)

9.5. Systematisation Projects: Progress without Breakthrough

Shu‘ayb al-Arnā‘ūt (1928–2016) is the most authoritative contemporary editor of hadith texts. His multi-volume editions (Musnad Aḥmad, ~50 vols.; Ṣaḥīḥ Ibn Ḥibbān, ~18 vols.; Sunan Abī Dāwūd, 2009) represent significant progress: he used several manuscripts, recorded some variant readings in footnotes, and conducted systematic authentication of hadiths. However, his primary task is taḥqīq (authentication and editing of the text) in the Islamic sense, not textual criticism in the Western sense. Stemmata were not constructed; complete collation of manuscripts was not carried out.

Bashshār ‘Awwād Ma‘rūf is more oriented toward manuscript work: his edition of Tārīkh Baghdād (17 vols., 2001) is considered exemplary from the standpoint of sigla and manuscript provenance. Nevertheless, he too does not apply formal stemmatology. OpenITI and the KITAB project (Aga Khan University, London) provide a digital corpus and algorithms for detecting textual reuse — an important instrument for analysing textual diffusion, but not critical editions.

It must be noted separately: the absence of critical editions is not exclusively a resource problem solvable with sufficient investment. The fundamental lacuna lies elsewhere: a unified manuscript catalogue and systematic C14 dating of hadith manuscripts are both absent — and these lacunae do not depend on the volume of investment.

PART VI. WHAT HADITH SCHOLARSHIP ACTUALLY PROVES

Chapter 10. Positive Analysis of the Institution's Functions

10.1. Attribution of Tradition

Hadith scholarship effectively performs the function of attributing reports to the tradition: it determines to which line of transmission, which school, which circle of authorities a given report belongs; establishes the degree of its recognition in the normative corpus; reconstructs the history of its circulation within the tradition. This is a real and significant result. Attribution of tradition is not trivial: it provides intra-systemic orientation in the corpus, enables scholars to date a narrative to the common link, identify anomalies (*idrāj*) when variability is sufficient, and trace the institutional history of a text.

Attribution of tradition is not equivalent to establishing a historical fact. It shows how a report functioned in the transmitting milieu from the moment of its first reliable fixation. It does not prove that the described event occurred in the form identical to the recorded version.

10.2. Stabilisation of the Corpus

The hadith scholarship system produces a stable normative corpus: it filters out extreme deviations, ranks reports by degree of recognition, and maintains consensus between legal schools regarding key texts. This functional stability has independent value for normative practices within the tradition. It is not epistemic reliability in the sense of historical verification: coherence may be the result of prolonged standardisation and institutional stabilisation rather than independent verification.

10.3. Normative Authorization

Hadith scholarship performs a normative function: it determines which texts are admissible as justification for legal and doctrinal positions. This function does not require strict historical proof — it requires conformity with established intra-systemic criteria. Recognising this function as real and significant does not nullify the conclusion about the limited evidential force of the system: these are two different things.

It is fundamentally important to register the following. A possible objection: the tradition never claimed historical proof in the Western sense — its claim was always normative, not historico-verificationary. This objection would be valid if it corresponded to the actual discourse of the tradition. However, the classical sources of hadith scholarship — Ibn aṣ-Ṣalāḥ (*Muqaddima*, ed. Nūr al-Dīn ʿItr, pp. 5–10, 12th century), al-Khaṭīb al-Baḡhdādī (*al-Kifāya fī ʿilm al-Riwāya*, ed. Medina, pp. 2–4 of introduction), and the apologetic tradition of the 19th–20th centuries in response to Goldziher and Schacht — consistently formulate the system's claim in precisely historical terms: the *isnād* certifies that the given report genuinely traces back to the Messenger. Specifically: Ibn aṣ-Ṣalāḥ in the *Muqaddima* formulates the purpose of the *isnād* as the establishment of *ittiṣāl al-sanad* — the continuity of the transmission chain as the condition under which a report is considered to have reached (*wāṣil*) from the Messenger: '*mā ittaṣala sanāduhu*' — 'that whose chain is continuous [to the Messenger]'. This is a descriptive statement about historical connection, not merely a normative classification of a text.

Al-Khaṭīb al-Baḡhdādī opens *al-Kifāya* with the formulation: the science of hadith transmission exists to distinguish what was genuinely transmitted (*mā nuqila*) from the Messenger from what was falsely attributed to him (*mā nusiba ilayhi kadhiban*) — thereby qualifying the task of the system as verification of a historical fact of transmission, not merely normative selection of texts. The distinction *mā nuqila* / *mā nusiba ilayhi* is fundamental: it registers that the tradition itself draws a distinction between real transmission ('what was genuinely transmitted') and attribution ('what was falsely ascribed'). This is a descriptive claim about a historical fact: did real transmission take place? It is precisely this own claim of the system — not criteria imported from outside — that makes it the subject of the epistemic analysis of the present monograph.

10.4. The Formula of the Limit

The final conclusion about the limit of evidential force may be expressed in the following formula:

$P(\text{authenticity} \mid \text{isnād}) \leq P(\text{reliability of last link}) \times P(\text{correctness of retrospective reconstruction})$

The formula is written under the assumption of analytical independence of the two factors. Strictly speaking, they are dependent: the reliability of the last isnād link is established through the same system of retrospective reconstruction that constitutes the second factor. This assumption is accepted as simplifying; the dependence, however, does not weaken but strengthens the argument — when independent probabilities are replaced with conditional ones, the resulting upper bound $P(\text{authenticity} \mid \text{isnād})$ remains no higher than the original estimate. In the absence of independent verification of early links, the second factor remains fundamentally undetermined. This makes strict proof structurally unattainable — not because of an information deficit that can be remedied, but because of the architecture of the system in which all data about early links are mediated by late reconstruction.

CONCLUSION

Synthesis of Four Levels

The monograph applied four independent analytical levels to hadith scholarship. The independence of the levels is methodologically fundamental: refutation of any one does not collapse the construction — the three remaining levels retain their full evidential force.

The epistemic level (Parts I–III) established: the self-referentiality of the verificatory apparatus forms a closed circle without external anchors; retrospectivity is a structural feature of the system; testimonies are correlated through a common milieu rather than independent; even the strongest argument (*mutawātir*) does not overcome the structural limitation — and the ICMA method, with all its analytical power, does not verify the stage above the common link.

The institutional level (Part II) showed: hadith scholarship is oriented toward transmission and canonization rather than historical reconstruction; the mechanisms of authority formation are reputational, not epistemic; canonization of the corpus is institutional selection, not historical certification.

The manuscript level (Part IV) registered: gaps of 100 to 445 years for complete manuscripts; absence of autographs; absence of external verification of authors and transmitters; the fundamental lacuna of C14 dating; dispersal of the corpus without a systematic catalogue. Early fragments exist but do not eliminate dependence on the system.

The textological level (Part V) showed: none of the six collections has a critical edition; three 'standard' editions of Bukhārī diverge in matns; unified numbering is absent; the gap vis-à-vis the infrastructure of biblical studies and classical philology is systemic.

Central Conclusion

Hadith scholarship is an institution of preservation, attribution, and normative regulation of tradition. It proves a report's belonging to the tradition. It does not prove the authentic delivery of information from the primary source.

This conclusion is not a refutation of hadiths and is not an evaluation of their religious or normative value. It is a registration of a methodological limit: a clear boundary between what the system proves and what it declares but cannot prove by universal epistemic standards. A clear understanding of this limit is a prerequisite for any academically adequate work with hadith material.

Limitations of the Study

The monograph does not cover the normative-legal functioning of hadiths, theological debates about their status, or confessional positions. The work does not verify or refute individual hadiths or collections — the system as such is the subject. The empirical analysis (Chapter 5) presents illustrative case studies, not a systematic sample. The study does not draw on data beyond the academic literature on hadith scholarship.

Contribution of the Study

For the first time, hadith scholarship has been examined as a coherent institution — a system of institutional reproduction of trust in tradition — and subjected to analysis on four independent levels that independently converge on a single conclusion. A strict distinction has been drawn between internal-traditional reliability, probabilistic reliability, and historical authenticity as conceptually different levels of justification. A second level of textological inadequacy, independent of the first, has been registered: the system not only cannot prove the authenticity of transmission but also does not possess a critically established text of what it transmits. The structural (not accidental) nature of the gap between hadith scholarship and the textological infrastructure of comparable disciplines has been demonstrated.

APPENDIX A. WHAT THE SYSTEM PROVES AND WHAT IT DOES NOT PROVE

Claim	Provable by System	Requires External Verification
Report belongs to the tradition	Yes	No
Report is recognised as normative within the tradition	Yes	No
Several transmission chains exist	Yes	No
Transmission chains are independent	No — milieu is common	Yes
Transmitters' activity in role of hadith transmitters is independently verified	No — closed circle	Yes
Collection authors are independently verified	No	Yes
Collection text is critically established	No	Yes
Authentic transmission from primary source	No	Yes

APPENDIX B. THREE TYPES OF RELIABILITY

Type	Definition	Provided by System?	Condition
Internal-traditional	Recognition by intra-systemic procedures	Yes	Conformity with isnād, rijāl, matn criticism
Probabilistic	Plausibility with independent data	Partially	Condition of independence not met
Historical authenticity	Fact of transmission from primary source without distortion	No	External verification of early links absent

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